

# Effective line redistribution in kilonova ejecta: transport-relevant structure is frequency-local

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## Abstract

A reduced model of a many-body process is usually judged by how well it reproduces the microscopic dynamics it replaces. We show, for lanthanide line fluorescence in kilonova ejecta, that this criterion selects the wrong model. Holding the atomic physics, the resolved line opacity and the physical state fixed, we compare two reduced representations of the redistribution of absorbed energy across frequency: a coarse graining into contiguous frequency groups, and a global non-negative factorisation with the same number of archetypal exit distributions and many more free parameters. The global representation reproduces the microscopic redistribution events 1.8 times better and the emergent broad-band light 20.8 times worse. Frequency locality, not fidelity to the microscopic distribution, is the structure the radiation samples. The local operator reaches a 0.10 mag photometric criterion with a handful of groups where the best scalar thermalisation closure misses by more than a magnitude; it remains compact across gas temperature, density, illumination and a realistic 13-ion mixture, where 4 groups suffice and the scalar closure misses by 1.69 mag; but it is state dependent, interpolable along single state coordinates and not along a coupled trajectory, and for one ion its required resolution changes with the state.

## 1 Introduction

When a process with millions of microscopic degrees of freedom is replaced by a reduced model, the reduction is normally built and judged against the microscopic dynamics: the reduced model that reconstructs the fine-grained process most accurately is taken to be the best. Goal-oriented model reduction has long recognised that the appropriate reduced model can depend on the quantity one wants from it [Benner et al., 2015], and reduced and low-rank formulations of radiative transfer exist [Peng et al., 2020]. The question we address is narrower and physical: in a concrete transport problem where the microscopic process can be simulated exactly, which of its degrees of freedom actually reach the observable radiation, and does fidelity to the microscopic process identify them?

The process is lanthanide line fluorescence in the ejecta of a neutron-star merger. The open  $f$ -shells of the lanthanides carry of order  $10^6$  transitions per ion at the relevant temperatures [Barnes and Kasen, 2013, Tanaka et al., 2020]; a photon absorbed in one line is re-emitted, after a cascade through the ion’s levels, in another, and this redistribution of energy across frequency is the dominant non-local process shaping a kilonova’s light. High-fidelity transport keeps the identity of every transition for exactly this reason: line-by-line calculations with tens of millions of lines follow the absorption and the cascade explicitly, through a stochastic macroatom [Lucy, 2002, 2003, Shingles et al., 2023]. Cheaper calculations replace the cascade by a parameterised redistribution — a scalar thermalisation probability  $\epsilon$  that sends a fraction of the absorbed energy to a thermal pool and scatters the rest coherently, or a frequency-grouped treatment of the opacity

with a prescribed re-emission within each group [Fontes et al., 2020]. Frequency redistribution as a formalism is classical [Hummer, 1962]; what is not known is how much of the fluorescence response a transport calculation needs, and what organises the part it needs.

We hold the opacity at the resolved Sobolev value of every line, take an energy-conserving downward macroatom as the exact reference, and build reduced operators from the reference’s own events on one set of random seeds, scoring them on another. Three preregistered gates then ask, in order, whether a compact operator exists where the scalar closure fails (Section 3); whether the structure it exploits is locality in frequency or a globally low rank of the redistribution law (Section 4); and whether that structure survives changes of state and composition (Section 5). The second gate is the result of this Letter. At matched complexity, the representation that reproduces the microscopic redistribution better reproduces the light worse, and the data identify frequency locality as the missing organising principle. In lanthanide fluorescence transport, generic fidelity to the microscopic redistribution does not identify the degrees of freedom that control the emergent radiation; a frequency-local representation does.

## 2 Set-up

Every calculation is a single-zone transport through the photospheric shell of a published lanthanide-rich ejecta model at two days, with the shell’s own density, gas temperature and expansion time and a black-body core illuminating it. One ion at a time — La II, Ce II or Nd II, at its number density in the shell, with levels and lines from a calibrated atomic data set [Flörs et al., 2026] and populations in local thermodynamic equilibrium — carries the opacity; La II is thin enough at its partial density that every closure agrees, and is a control. Packets carry indivisible energy. The reference is a downward macroatom: on absorption the packet walks the radiative cascade with branching probabilities  $A\beta$  until it exits in a line whose photon escapes, conserving energy at every step; the identity between injected and accounted energy is verified to  $10^{-10}$  on every run.

The reduced operator is built from the reference’s events (absorbed frequency, exit frequency, energy before and after). On  $N_g$  log-spaced frequency groups,  $R_{ij}$  is the fraction of energy absorbed in group  $i$  that exits in group  $j$ ; within each output group the exit line is drawn from a discrete table of the distinct exit lines the events populated, weighted by energy. Transport with the operator replaces the cascade by one draw from  $R_{ij}$  and one from the table. Operators are built on three seeds and scored on three disjoint seeds. The global family of Section 4 replaces the transition matrix by a rank- $k$  non-negative factorisation of the fine-grouped matrix on the same exit tables; the state-dependent operators of Section 5 are rebuilt at, transported to, or interpolated between states as described there. Every closure is scored by its maximum absolute error in the broad-band magnitudes and colours over the bands that carry at least one per cent of the luminosity, by an integrated spectral distance, and by an energy-weighted total-variation distance to an independent fine-grouped matrix from the evaluation events; the criterion throughout is 0.10 mag in band and 0.10 mag in colour. The gates, their readings and the amendments made during the runs are in the End Matter.

## 3 A compact operator exists where a scalar closure fails

The optimally tuned scalar misses the reference by 1.40 mag on Ce II and 1.06 mag on Nd II; the group operator meets the criterion at  $N_g = 16$  and  $N_g = 2$  (Fig. 1a). The compression is not an artefact of one cascade prescription: replacing the reference by a radiation-field-driven macroatom with internal upward transitions moves the photometry by 2.09 mag on Ce II, and an operator

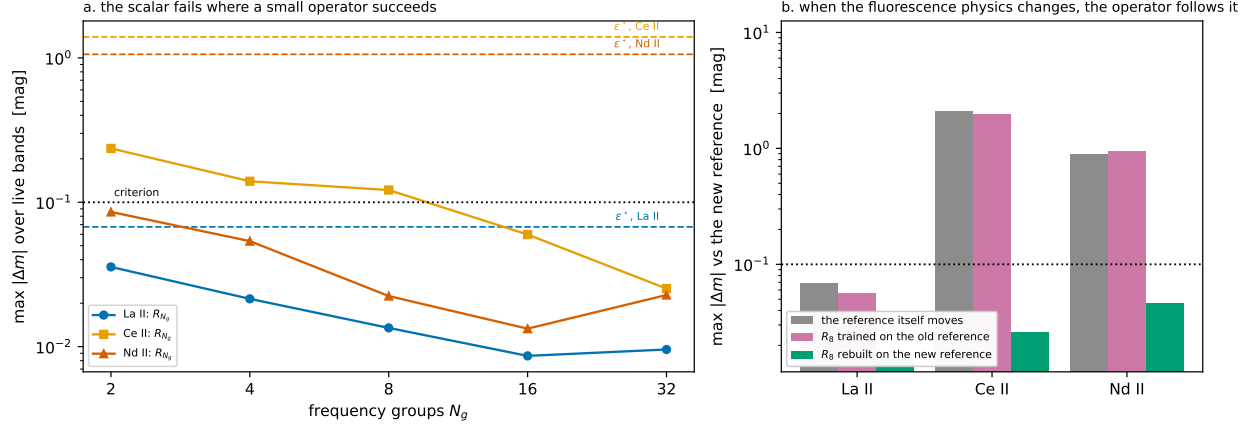


Figure 1: **A scalar closure fails where a small operator succeeds, and the operator follows the fluorescence physics.** (a) Maximum photometric error against the energy-conserving downward macroatom for the group operator at  $N_g = 2 \dots 32$  (solid) and the optimally tuned scalar  $\epsilon^*$  (dashed). (b) Under a radiation-field-driven macroatom the reference itself moves (grey); an operator rebuilt from its events follows it (green); the operator trained on the previous reference does not (pink).

rebuilt from that reference follows it to 0.026 mag while the operator trained on the original reference stays 1.96 mag away (Fig. 1b). The operator carries the fluorescence physics it is built from. This establishes that there is a non-trivial reduced model to explain; the explanation is the next section.

## 4 Observable fidelity is not microscopic fidelity

Two families of operator were built on identical exit tables and identical opacity, differing only in the group-to-group matrix: local coarsening into  $N_g$  contiguous frequency blocks, and a global non-negative factorisation into  $k$  archetypal exit distributions mixed freely for every fine input group. The matched axis is the number of archetypes. At equal count the global family is far the more expressive, with 8,192 free numbers against 1,024 at 32 archetypes, and it fits the microscopic redistribution better by construction. If the compression of Section 3 reflected a globally low-rank redistribution law, the global family would reach the photometric criterion with fewer archetypes.

It does not. On Ce II the local operator passes at 16 archetypes and the global one at 32; on Nd II the local operator passes at 2 and the global family is undefined at every rank tried. The contrast is sharpest where both are measured at the same count. At 32 archetypes on Nd II the global operator's event-level total-variation loss is 0.075 against the local operator's 0.132, and its photometric error is 0.162 mag against 0.008 mag:

$$E_{\text{micro}}^{\text{global}} < E_{\text{micro}}^{\text{local}}, \quad E_{\text{obs}}^{\text{global}} > E_{\text{obs}}^{\text{local}}, \quad (1)$$

by factors of 1.8 and 20.8 respectively, and the same inversion holds on every ion (Fig. 2). The degrees of freedom that minimise a generic distance between microscopic redistribution distributions are not the degrees of freedom that carry the radiation field. What the radiation samples is that neighbouring absorbed frequencies share a transport-relevant response: an operator that keeps contiguous frequencies together reproduces the light with a few blocks, and a factorisation free to mix distant frequencies, however well it reconstructs the events, does not.

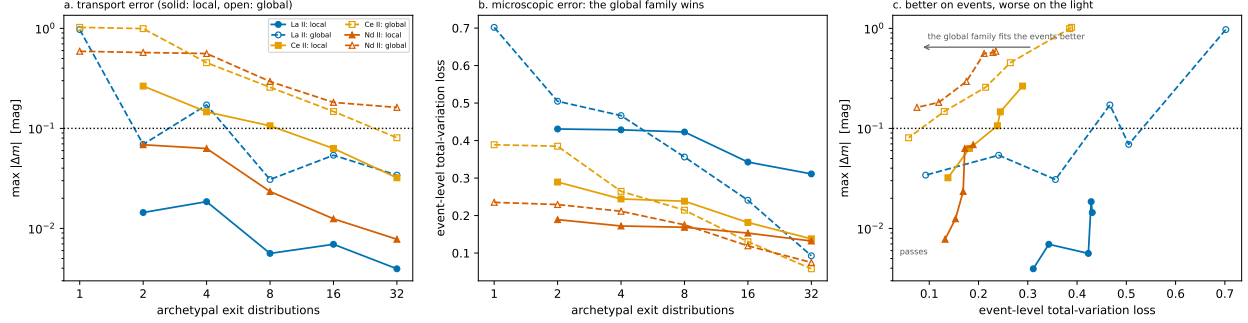


Figure 2: **Better on the microscopic events, worse on the light.** (a) Photometric error and (b) event-level total-variation loss against the number of archetypal exit distributions, for local frequency coarsening (solid) and the global factorisation (open). (c) The two against each other: the global points move left, fitting the microscopic redistribution better, while staying high, reproducing the emergent light worse.

The compression is two-level. Writing  $P(\nu_{\text{out}} | \nu_{\text{in}}) = P(j | i) P(\nu_{\text{out}} | i, j)$ , the first factor is extremely coarse, while the second still needs a sparse but real set of exit lines: truncating the exit tables by retained energy, the light needs 0.358 of the distinct exit lines on Ce II and 0.113 on Nd II at the same thresholds. We do not claim that the atomic network has only a handful of degrees of freedom. We claim that the part of it the transport needs is organised by frequency locality, and that microscopic reconstruction error does not find it.

## 5 A state-dependent family, compact throughout

Is the local operator a property of the ion or of the state it was built in? We moved one coordinate at a time from the original state along 4 axes — gas temperature, number density, the temperature of the illuminating source, and the physical trajectory at one, three and five days along which all of them move together — and at each of 14 states per ion scored, against that state’s own reference, both the original operator transported unchanged and an operator rebuilt there (Fig. 3), both at 16 groups. The transported operator is not predictive: it fails on every axis for Ce II and on all but the source-spectrum axis for the other two ions. The rebuilt operator passes at every readable state of Nd II and La II, with at most 4 groups needed anywhere on Nd II. There is no universal  $R_{ij}$ ; the failure of transfer is not a failure of compression.

What varies is the content of a small operator, and it varies smoothly along single coordinates. At the interior point of each axis an operator interpolated linearly in the logarithm of the moved coordinate between the two bracketing states — transition rows, deposition channel and exit tables on the union of the endpoints’ exit lines, never using the interior state’s events — passes the criterion on the temperature, density and source axes for every ion, reducing Nd II’s error at the interior temperature from 0.150 to 0.032 mag. The useful object is a tabulated family  $R(\theta)$ . Its boundary is the coupled trajectory: at three days on Nd II the transported operator misses by 0.181 mag, the interpolant by 0.117 mag, and only the operator rebuilt there passes, at 2 groups with 0.013 mag. The family is compact but not separable in independently varied coordinates; interpolation was tested one axis at a time and the one coupled path tested breaks it. Ce II adds a second qualification: its rebuilt 16-group operator fails at 7 of 14 states, on colour, by at most 0.062 mag, and a 32-group operator passes at every one. Compactness survives; a fixed representation size does not.

Composition closes the argument. Three single-ion operators combined by an opacity-share

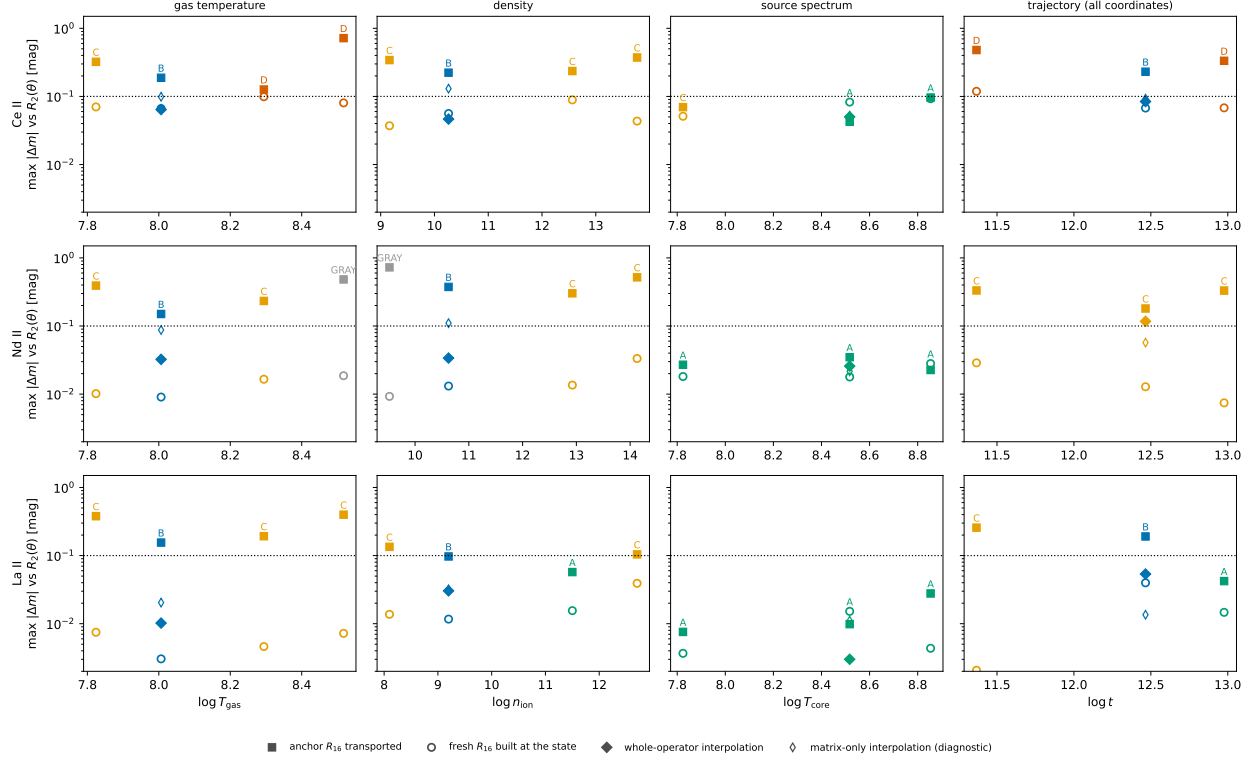


Figure 3: **Transfer is not compression.** Maximum photometric error against the state’s own reference for the original operator transported unchanged (filled squares), the operator rebuilt at the state (open circles), and at each axis’ interior point the whole-operator interpolant from the two bracketing states (filled diamonds; matrix-only interpolant, open diamonds). Rows: Ce II, Nd II, the La II control; columns: gas temperature, density, source spectrum, and the trajectory along which all move together. Dotted: the band criterion; the letter is the preregistered reading of each state (A transported operator passes; B only the interpolant; C only a fresh fit; D none at 16 groups). The criterion also bounds the colour error, so a circle below the line can read D. Grey: states excluded by the preregistered validity checks.

rule, with no fit to the blend, do not reach the criterion at any valid resolution (0.142 mag at best), while an operator built on the three-ion blend passes at 4 groups: per-species operators do not compose. Yet on the full 13-ion composition of the benchmark state — the mixture a transport calculation actually needs — the operator built on the blend passes at 4 groups (0.088 mag in band, 0.073 in colour) while the best scalar closure misses by 1.69 mag, the widest scalar failure in this work. The combined physical system is itself highly compressible even though it cannot be assembled from its parts.

## 6 Conclusions

Of the order  $10^6$  transitions of a lanthanide ion, the transport sees a fine distribution of redistribution events; of that distribution, the emergent light sees a small frequency-local operator; and most of the information between the two is discarded without harm. The decisive evidence is the inversion of Eq. (1): a representation that reproduces the microscopic redistribution better reproduces

the light worse, so the microscopic distribution is the wrong target for a reduced model of this process and frequency locality is the right one. The local operator is not universal — it is a state-dependent family, interpolable along single coordinates, refit where coordinates move together, with a resolution that is itself state-dependent for Ce II — and it does not compose from single species; but on the realistic mixture it is as compact as on any single ion. The limitations are those of the set-up: single-zone, time-independent, with the radiation field imposed and its influence measured only through the source-spectrum axis, on one coupled path. None of them touches the inversion, which is measured on identical events, identical opacity and identical observables. Transport can discard most of the microscopic fluorescence information — but only if the reduced coordinates respect the structure the radiation actually samples.

## End Matter

**The gates.** Each of the three questions was preregistered as a gate — the state, the grids, the metrics, the thresholds, the gray conditions that invalidate a reading and the readings themselves fixed and committed before the run — and read gray-first. Table 1 gives the per-ion readings of the first gate (the group count at which the operator meets the criterion, the best scalar and its error) and of the second (the archetype counts of the local and global families, and the fraction of exit lines the light needs), with the robustness check against the radiation-field-driven macroatom; Table 2 the microscopic and observable errors of Eq. (1) at 32 archetypes on every ion; Table 3 the third gate per ion — its three readings, the axes along which the transported operator stays predictive, how often the rebuilt operator fails and the largest resolution it needed, and the interpolation error at each single-coordinate interior point, whole operator against transition matrix alone. The third gate’s first reading is Red for Ce II (the resolution result above) and its second Red for Nd II (the trajectory); its mixture readings are Yellow for composability and Green for the realistic blend.

**Amendments during the runs.** Three were made and are recorded in the archived preregistration with what had been seen when each was made. In the second gate, two implementation defects in computing the factorisation (a live row sent to zero; a fixed iteration count that had not converged) were found on the control ion and fixed before any decisive ion’s numbers were read, and a validity control that compared the local family on coarse and fine exit tables fired on both decisive ions and was answered by its preregistered remedy, transporting the local family on the shared fine tables; no threshold changed. In the third gate, an unclamped cumulative-sum sampler overflowed on the 13-ion mixture, the largest line list in this work; it was fixed with the clip its sibling samplers already carried, its reachability in every earlier record was established by inspection (any overflow crashes, so no completed record could have been affected), and the mixture calculation was repeated. A separate, non-reproducible corruption of one energy-accounting sum in three runs was audited by rerunning each, found not to affect the photometry, and answered by excluding any run with an invalid energy ledger from every reading.

**Transport and validation.** The transport is a Monte Carlo Sobolev code with worldline relativity and energy packets, developed and validated in a companion methods paper on coarse line-opacity treatments (in preparation). The properties this Letter relies on are verified within it: the energy identity closes to  $10^{-10}$  on every run reported; the resolved Sobolev transport is pinned against a deterministic formal-solution reference; the downward macroatom reproduces an explicit cascade’s energy per line; and every operator is built on seeds disjoint from those it is scored on.

The generality test lays every kernel of an ion on one frequency support frozen over the whole state domain, so that an operator transported between states is never clipped to a different range.

**Data availability.** The transport code, the preregistrations of the three gates, every run record, the frozen record from which every number in this Letter is generated, and the scripts that regenerate the numbers, tables and figures are archived at [github.com/zhuygln/revisit\\_sobolev](https://github.com/zhuygln/revisit_sobolev) (tags `paperB-g2-prereg`, `paperB-g2-freeze`, `paperB-g3-prereg`, `paperB-g3-freeze`).

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Table 1: The first two gates, per ion.

| ion   | $N_g^*$ | $\epsilon^*$ | error at $\epsilon^*$<br>[mag] | $K_{\text{local}}^*$ | $K_{\text{global}}^*$ | $L^*$ | $R_8$ vs the new reference<br>[mag] |
|-------|---------|--------------|--------------------------------|----------------------|-----------------------|-------|-------------------------------------|
| La II | 2       | 0.20         | 0.07                           | 2                    | 2                     | 0.504 | 0.015                               |
| Ce II | 16      | 0.00         | 1.40                           | 16                   | 32                    | 0.358 | 0.026                               |
| Nd II | 2       | 0.00         | 1.06                           | 2                    | undefined             | 0.113 | 0.046                               |

Table 2: Microscopic against observable error at 32 archetypes.

| ion   | $m_{\text{event}}$ global | $m_{\text{event}}$ local | max $ \Delta m $ global<br>[mag] | max $ \Delta m $ local<br>[mag] |
|-------|---------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| La II | 0.093                     | 0.311                    | 0.034                            | 0.004                           |
| Ce II | 0.058                     | 0.138                    | 0.081                            | 0.032                           |
| Nd II | 0.075                     | 0.132                    | 0.162                            | 0.008                           |

Table 3: The third gate, per ion: the readings, the axes along which the transported operator stays predictive, how often the rebuilt 16-group operator fails and the largest resolution it needed, and the interior-point interpolation error (whole operator / transition matrix only) on the three single-coordinate axes, in mag.

| ion   | C1    | C2     | C3     | transfer holds<br>(axes) | fresh $R_{16}$ fails<br>(of states) | max $K_{\text{rec}}^*$ | interp. $T$<br>whole / matrix | interp. error<br>whole |
|-------|-------|--------|--------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------|
| La II | GREEN | YELLOW | GREEN  | J                        | 0/ 14                               | 2                      | 0.010/ 0.020                  | 0.030                  |
| Ce II | RED   | YELLOW | YELLOW | none                     | 7/ 14                               | 32                     | 0.064/ 0.099                  | 0.047                  |
| Nd II | GREEN | RED    | GREEN  | J                        | 0/ 12                               | 4                      | 0.032/ 0.087                  | 0.034                  |